

05

Curiosity: Withholding the How

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If you're new to this series, start with ****What a Headline Actually Does****.

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The Curiosity Gap

Curiosity is the tension created by a gap between what the reader knows and what they want to know. It is the strongest raw force a headline can generate — and the most abused. Used well, curiosity is what makes a headline physically hard to scroll past. Used badly, it produces cheap clicks from confused readers who bounce the moment they land.

The difference is precision. Vague mystery is not curiosity. "You Won't Believe What Happens Next" opens a gap so shapeless that the reader has nothing to be curious *about*. Productive curiosity is specific on the *what* and silent on the *how*. The reader should know exactly what result is being discussed, who it's for, and roughly why it matters — and be missing exactly one thing: how it works.

That's the rule this whole document turns on: **withhold the how, never the what.**

Old-school copywriters warned that curiosity alone is weak. Curiosity has to be welded to self-interest: the reader isn't curious as a hobby — they're curious because the answer might improve their life. A famous test of four competing headlines for the same diet product found that "Breakthrough New Diet Product!" (all news, no gap) and "A New Diet Revolution!" (all hype, no substance) both lost badly to headlines that paired a concrete, self-interested result with a withheld method.

The Mechanism: Giving the "How" a Name

The most reliable way to build a curiosity gap is to *name* the withheld how. Copywriters call this the **mechanism** — the specific method, ingredient, trick, or process behind the promised result, referenced by a memorable name but not explained.

Compare:

- "A tea that helps you sleep" — no mechanism, no gap, no reason to click. Tea is old news.
- "The 'Bio-Harmony Switch' that tells your body it's time to sleep" — now there is a *named thing* the reader has never heard of, doing something specific. The gap is precise: *what is the Bio-Harmony Switch and does it really work?*

A named mechanism accomplishes three things at once:

1. **It creates a precise gap.** The reader knows exactly what they don't know.
2. **It implies newness.** A named mechanism sounds like a discovery, not a rehash — which quietly answers the reader's most cynical objection: "I've tried everything already." The unspoken promise is: *not this, you haven't*.
3. **It survives skepticism.** A raw big promise triggers doubt; a promise routed through a mechanism gives the skeptical mind somewhere to park: "well... maybe there IS something to this gin-soaked-raisins thing."

One caution: the mechanism must be real. Naming is packaging, not invention. If your product genuinely works through a three-point support design, "the 3-Point Support Method" is honest packaging. If there is no method behind the name, you've written a lie with title case, and the funnel behind the headline will collapse under the broken promise.

The Partial Reveal

The craft skill here is dosage: how much of the mechanism do you show? The answer is a **partial reveal** — show the silhouette, withhold the workings.

A perfect classic example: "*Gin-Soaked Raisins Cured My 'Hopeless' Arthritis*." Notice how much is revealed: the entire mechanism's *ingredients* are right there in the headline — gin, raisins. And yet the gap is enormous: why would that work? How is it prepared? Why raisins? The reveal is what makes it credible and irresistible at once; nobody invents "gin-soaked raisins" as a fantasy.

The failure modes sit on either side:

- **Over-withholding:** "This Weird Trick Cured My Arthritis" — nothing to grip; reads as bait.
- **Over-revealing:** "Soaking Raisins in Gin May Reduce Joint Inflammation via Compound X — Here's the Full Protocol" — the gap is closed; the click is unnecessary.

The partial reveal lands in between: concrete enough to be believed, incomplete enough to demand the click.

Four Classic Swipes, Annotated

SWIPE

"Why Some Foods 'Explode' in Your Stomach" (a famous classic ad)

ANATOMY [Provocative "Why"] + [Ordinary Subject] + [Startling Mechanism Image].

WHY IT WORKS The scare-quoted "explode" is a partial reveal of a digestive mechanism — vivid enough to picture, unexplained enough to demand the read. And it's about food, so the self-interest is universal.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — a one-second image that stops the scroll and opens a precise loop.

SWIPE

"Kitchen Cure #619" (from a classic arthritis promotion)

ANATOMY [Humble Source] + [Oddly Specific Catalog Number].

WHY IT WORKS Three words carrying a double gap: what is the cure, and — more maddening — if this is #619, what are the other 618? "Kitchen" makes it simple and safe; the number makes it feel documented rather than invented. A masterclass in mechanism naming through pure specificity.

FUNNEL FIT Ad or advertorial headline unit — the number does the curiosity work on either surface.

SWIPE

"The Amazing Seduction Secrets of a Skinny, Ugly, 6-ft Geek" (a Halbert-style classic, widely analyzed in headline teaching)

ANATOMY [Withheld Secrets] + [Wildly Unlikely Messenger].

WHY IT WORKS The curiosity isn't in the secrets — "seduction secrets" alone would be generic. It's in the *contradiction*: this particular person shouldn't have these results, so his method must be something other than looks. The unlikely messenger IS the implied mechanism.

FUNNEL FIT Advertorial — a story headline that sells the read of a transformation narrative.

SWIPE

"This Woman Is Slimming Her Waistline — By Blowing Out the Candles On An Imaginary Cake!" (a famous classic)

ANATOMY [Result in Progress] + [Bizarre, Hyper-Specific Action].

WHY IT WORKS The action is fully revealed and still explains nothing — the perfect partial reveal. It's too strange to be invented and too specific to ignore. The reader's mind cannot construct the missing "why," so they have to read.

FUNNEL FIT Advertorial — bizarre-but-true is native editorial's home turf.

Fictional Before/After: Building the Gap

Imagine you're promoting a fictional device that cuts household electricity costs.

Before (no gap):

A New Way to Save on Power Bills.

"New way" is the emptiest phrase in advertising. There's no what, no how, no reason to believe there's anything behind the curtain.

After (named mechanism, partial reveal):

The 'Copper-Coil Trick' That Slashes Power Bills (Without Touching Your Thermostat)

Now there's a named mechanism ("Copper-Coil Trick" — concrete, physical, picturable), a specific promise (slashed bills), and a negation that sharpens the gap by removing the reader's first guess (it's not a thermostat thing — then what is it?). The what is fully delivered; only the how is withheld.

■ Calibrating Curiosity Across the Three Surfaces

Curiosity is not spread evenly across the funnel — it's front-loaded at the ad, and what happens to it next depends on the route.

- **Ad — maximum curiosity.** This is the gap's home. Open the loop, name or gesture at the mechanism, and do not close anything. The click *is* the reader's attempt to close the loop.
- **Advertorial — curiosity converted into story.** Re-open the ad's loop in the headline, then spend the page gradually paying it off: what the mechanism is, where it came from, why it works, who it's helped. Each partial payoff should open a smaller next-gap ("so how do I use it?") that pulls the reader down the page.
- **Jump page — the ad's loop, carried forward to the video.** This reader arrived straight from the ad, so the loop it opened is still nearly wide open — and the video, not the page, is where it closes. The jump-page headline restates the gap and aims it at the play button: the demonstration, the exact protocol, "watch how it works." What it must not do is open a *different* loop — a fresh, unrelated mystery breaks the scent the click was following.

✓ Key Takeaways

- Curiosity is a gap between what the reader knows and wants to know — and it only pulls when welded to self-interest.
- **Withhold the how, never the what.** Vague mystery is bait; precise incompleteness is craft.
- Name the mechanism: a specific, memorable name for the real method creates a precise gap, implies newness, and gives skepticism somewhere to park.
- Use the partial reveal — concrete enough to believe, incomplete enough to demand the next step. Beware both over-withholding and over-revealing.
- Spend curiosity by route: widest gap at the ad; then a story-paced payoff through the advertorial, or the same loop carried forward on the jump page and handed to the video.